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• theories that are hard to classify in traditional terms

In this chapter, we'll consider other metaethical theories that, in one way or another, reject some of the basic distinctions that we previously used to classify the four main theoretical traditions in metaethics. I will group these remaining theories into three main categories. First, there are several theories offering a more nuanced answer to the question: are ethical thoughts cognitive states ("belief-like") or conative states ("desire-like")? There are a few different ways to respond to this question by arguing that it is a false dichotomy. Perhaps ethical thoughts have belief-like *and* desire-like aspects or components. Second, there's a theoretical tradition tracing back to Hobbes' political philosophy whereby facts about political legitimacy are said to be "constructed" rather than, so to speak, already out there to be discovered. This is related to a tradition in moral philosophy that construes ethical properties as defined in part by the way people would react to situations under certain specified circumstances. Recently, some metaethicists have tried to extend and combine these ideas to defend the view that there are, in a sense, ethical facts but they are, quite generally, constructed out of the reactions of people in particular situations rather than already out there to be discovered. Third, quite independently of metaethics, some philosophers have expressed skepticism about the common model of language that assumes, as the default view, that statements are attempted representations of reality. As we've seen, expressivists argue that ethical statements are not attempted representations of reality, but they tend to assume that's an exception to the general rule about assertoric language. However, rather than see the burden of proof on anti-representationalists about ethical statements, a more general antirepresentationalism in the philosophy of language might shift the burden of proof to representationalists. One of the main traditions in the philosophy of language is a view that explains meanings in terms of conceptual roles rather than representation. Here, we'll explore how it might provide some means for this burden-shifting move and its consequences for metaethics.

All of these ideas have knock-on effects for the way we think of the chart of metaethical theories and the dialectical situation one faces as one moves through that chart in search of the theory with the best ratio of theoretical benefits to costs.

• BELIEFS OR DESIRES—WHY NOT A BIT OF BOTH?

McDowell

In a set of papers far too rich to do full justice here, McDowell (1998, pt. 2) defends a metaethical view that doesn't fit neatly into our previous categories. This is mainly for two reasons.

First, McDowell defends a form of realism which he construes as naturalistic; however, he denies that ethical facts reduce to or otherwise “fit” among the scientifically discoverable facts. Rather than embrace nonnaturalism, however, he accuses other philosophers of a pernicious **scientism** in their conception of nature. That is, he suggests we have been wrong to think that the ultimate standard for determining whether a putative fact counts as a natural fact is whether it reduces to the kinds of fact that figure in the law-like explanations of empirical sciences. He argues instead for an expansion of our conception of nature “beyond what is countenanced in a naturalism of the realm of law” (McDowell, 1994, 88). This is a conception of nature as including a set of facts about reasons for action that are not discoverable by science but only by developing our wisdom through a process of socialization in community and practical education. He writes, “the picture is that ethics involves requirements of reason that are there whether we know it or not, and our eyes are opened to them by the acquisition of ‘practical wisdom’” (1994, 79).

It's worth noting that, like Foot and Hursthouse, McDowell is inspired by Aristotle, but his claim to be a naturalist about ethical facts is importantly different from theirs. They propose to expand a previously narrow conception of scientifically discoverable facts (consisting mainly of physical and chemical facts) to also include facts about human nature (discoverable through sciences like biology, ethology, anthropology, sociology, etc.); and from this they try to derive ethical facts from facts about how humans should be in light of our characteristic way of living. So they would seem to accept that science is our route to knowledge of the natural world; they just accept a more capacious understanding of what counts as science than is typically presupposed by metaethical discussion of naturalism. By contrast, McDowell's suggestion is that it's simply wrong to think that science is the arbiter of what facts really obtain as part of nature. This means that, although he adopts the mantle of “naturalism,” he doesn't show how ethical facts reduce to or otherwise fit among facts uncontroversially regarded as natural.

Second, McDowell rejects the Humean psychology of motivation that was a background assumption in much of our previous discussion of various metaethical views. That is, he denies that the mental states contributing to the motivation to act can

always be neatly divided into those which aim to fit the way the world is and those that aim to change the world to fit them. Instead, he thinks that ethical knowledge involves intertwined descriptive and directive aspects of our thought that make it impossible to factor neatly into “belief-like” and “desire-like” components. This rejection of the Humean psychology of motivation makes room for the suggestion that there is some knowledge that one simply cannot have without also being (at least partially) motivated in certain ways. His thought is that ethical knowledge is like that—it has both cognitive and conative aspects, but these cannot be factored into separable components.

To appreciate what McDowell has in mind, let’s consider an example. Assume that a good person knows, and so believes, that spreading damaging gossip is a nasty thing to do. McDowell’s suggestion is that a belief like this one is a fully cognitive state of mind: it represents the action of spreading damaging gossip as being a nasty thing to do. However, he’d also say that one doesn’t count as having that belief unless one is motivated to avoid spreading damaging gossip. This is the case not because the content of the belief implicates desires, rather it’s because the belief itself guarantees (partial) motivation to avoid spreading damaging gossip. The idea is that to count as applying the concept “a nasty thing to do” in the full-fledged way characteristic of ethical knowledge, one must have enough practical wisdom to be motivated not to do things to which one applies this concept.¹

If this is right, McDowell can endorse a form of motivational internalism without having to follow the expressivist in saying that ethical judgments express desire-like attitudes rather than beliefs. That means that by giving up on the Humean psychology of motivation, he aspires to the advantage expressivists claimed over rival theories to capture motivational internalism about ethical judgments. But he does so without succumbing to the disadvantages expressivism seems to suffer in making sense of the semantics of ethical language and the possibility of genuine ethical knowledge.

QUI: What would a Humean about motivation say about the example of someone’s believing that spreading gossip is a nasty thing to do?

To assess this view for yourself, you’ll want to consider whether you find McDowell’s soft naturalism too soft to fit with your prior views about naturalism about what’s real. You’ll also want to consider whether it’s acceptable to reject the Humean psychology of motivation.

Ecumenical expressivism

A different way to try to get some of the advantages of expressivism while avoiding some of the disadvantages is to be “ecumenical” about what mental states are expressed by ethical judgments. That is, when asked whether ethical judgments express cognitive or noncognitive states, some philosophers respond with: why not both?

We can divide metaethical views pursuing this strategy into two groups. The first group is *expressivist* in the sense that, like other expressivists, they think it is crucial to understanding the meaning of ethical sentences that we view them as conventional vehicles for expressing conative states. However, they are **ecumenical expressivists** because they also think part of the story about the meaning of ethical sentences will also advert to their being conventional vehicles for expressing cognitive states linked to the conative states in the right way.²

There are several different ways to work out this idea. But the basic form is to start with the thought that all sentences mean what they do partially in virtue of the states of mind conventionally linked to them. Then the ecumenical expressivist argues that the state of mind linked in this way to an ethical sentence is a kind of hybrid consisting of both conative and cognitive elements. For example, a traditional expressivist might claim that the sentence “Stealing is wrong” means what it does partially in virtue of expressing disapproval. However, there’s room to argue that this is not disapproval of some specific action, person, state of affairs, etc. but rather disapproval of things in general, insofar as they have a particular property—what might be thought of as the naturalistic basis of the disapproval (e.g., the property of causing a lot of pain). And making that move would allow one also to claim that this sentence means what it does partially in virtue of expressing a belief that stealing has that property (e.g., the property of causing a lot of pain). That is, a simple version of ecumenical expressivism says that the meaning of the sentence is a matter of its expressing both disapproval of things insofar as they have some natural property, call it *F*, and a belief that stealing is *F*. In short, ethical sentences mean what they do because they express both a belief and a desire-like state.

In a quasi-realist spirit, ecumenical expressivists usually go on to insist that there’s nothing wrong with claiming that ethical sentences simply express ethical “beliefs,” as long as we recognize that the nature of these beliefs is hybrid in the sense that they contain both cognitive representations of reality as being a certain way (e.g., stealing causes a lot of pain) and noncognitive attitudes linked to this belief in the right way (e.g., disapproval of things insofar as they cause a lot of pain). The view intended as a form of expressivism because the mental state expressed by ethical sentences is, as part of why these sentences have the meanings that they do, partially noncognitive. This means that, although ethical thought represents ways reality could be on this view, the ecumenical expressivist isn’t committed to the reality of genuinely ethical properties. It’s only the cognitive element of an ethical thought that represents reality.

Ecumenical expressivists characteristically claim to get the “best of both worlds” when it comes to the cognitivism vs. noncognitivism debate. Like cognitivists, they can explain why ethical thought often behaves in ways characteristic of belief (e.g., its content can be embedded in various ways related to the Frege–Geach Problem); but like noncognitivists they can explain why ethical thought behaves in ways characteristic of desires (e.g., it has the potential to motivate action without the help of further desires).

Key Point: Ecumenical expressivists think that ethical thoughts (i.e. the mental states expressed by ethical statements) are hybrid in that they have separable cognitive and conative elements.

To assess this view for yourself, you'll want to consider whether there is a *principled* motivation for pasting cognitive and conative elements together in our view of ethical thought. If not, ecumenical expressivism begins to look to be an ad hoc amalgamation of two competing ideas motivated only by the fact that neither is completely defensible. You'll also want to consider whether the view really does get the best of both worlds, and whether the price it pays for this (mainly in theoretical complexity when it comes to the philosophy of language and philosophy of mind) is worth that, given other options.

Hybrid cognitivism

The second group of philosophers pursuing the “why not both?” strategy are ethical naturalists who find room for the expression of desire-like states somewhere else in their overall philosophy of language as it applies to ethical discourse. Recall that ethical naturalists are realists, but unlike nonnaturalists they hold that ethical facts are a species of natural fact. In Chapter 5, we discussed various strategies naturalists have pursued for explaining which natural facts are the ethical facts. On some of these, the ethical claims turn out to be (perhaps surprisingly) about our own motivations, in which case it is explicable how the beliefs expressed by these claims might be tightly connected to motivation. However, those views have subjectivist or relativist implications (leading to difficulty explaining moral disagreement, and the problem of delimiting the relevant community) that many find unpalatable. But all of the other alternatives seem committed to denying that ethical beliefs are *internally* connected to motivation; and being driven to motivational externalism seems to many to be a theoretical cost. But it wouldn't be such a cost if ethical statements were thought to express not only beliefs about some natural fact but also some desire-like state of mind. Unlike the ecumenical expressivist, however, **hybrid cognitivists** argue that this isn't due to the literal meaning of the relevant sentences but rather some aspect of their pragmatic function or characteristic use.

To understand what this might mean, it's helpful to understand the phenomenon of **implicature**. Grice (1989) pointed out that what someone says and what they mean in saying it are not always the same; indeed often we say one thing but mean another. Grice called this phenomenon “implicature”; the idea being that there's often a difference between the literal content of one's assertion and what one implicates by this assertion. There is a rich literature on the various kinds of implicature, but we can restrict our focus to two kinds.

First, contextual elements of an ongoing conversation are often tacitly employed by speakers to implicate something and tracked by hearers to make sense of what the speaker means. For example, if we meet on the street during a week of rainy weather, you might say, “It’s another nice day.” Although your assertion literally means *that it is another nice day*, you don’t mean that and I know you don’t mean that. You implicate something like, “The weather this week has been horrible.” This phenomenon is called **conversational implicature** because the implicature is achieved through variable features of the context in which the statement is made (i.e. the weather conditions of which speaker and hearer are both fully aware) rather than anything having to do with the conventions with which we use words. Because of this, it doesn’t seem to be part of our specifically linguistic abilities that we can understand how what someone means differs from the literal content of the sentences they use to express themselves; rather it’s part of our general purpose ability to keep track of sundry features of our environment and understand why other people do what they do.

Second, some words and phrases seem to have been conventionalized as mechanisms for implicating something. For example, on some views of the conjunctions ‘and’ and ‘but’ they carry the same literal semantic content (conjunction), but the latter also implicates that there is some tension between the two things conjoined. Consider the difference between someone saying, “He’s from the hills of eastern Kentucky and wicked smart,” and “He’s from the hills of eastern Kentucky but wicked smart.” Unlike the former, the latter suggests somehow that it is surprising that someone from the hills of eastern Kentucky might be wicked smart. Some philosophers of language attribute this to a convention attaching to ‘but’ which means that it implicates some tension between the elements it coordinates in a sentence. This phenomenon is called **conventional implicature**.

QU2: Imagine someone said “Even Joe passed the test,” what would this implicate?

It is controversial in linguistics and the philosophy of language how best to understand implicature and whether this division between conversational and conventional implicature is the right way to make sense of the linguistic phenomena. But using that distinction as a rough tool, we can now begin to see how an ethical naturalist might defend the claim that an ethical judgment expresses a belief about some natural fact but also expresses a desire-like attitude relevant for the psychology of motivation. The basic idea would be to argue that although ethical sentences are literally about natural facts, their use to make a statement implicates that the speaker has some desire-like attitude.

There are different versions of this idea. Using the model of conversational implicature, a hybrid cognitivist might argue that the expression of a desire-like attitude is a possible (or even common) feature of the context in which ethical sentences are ordinarily used, but not something that attaches to those sentences in virtue of the

linguistic conventions surrounding the words they contain. For instance, Finlay (2005) argues that ethical statements can conversationally implicate that the speaker desires some end or goal. On the other hand, using the model of conventional implicature, a hybrid cognitivist might instead argue that ethical words carry a conventionalized role of conveying that the speaker desires something. For instance, Copp (2001) argues that ethical statements conventionally implicate that the speaker desires (at least somewhat) to act in their accord.

There's another way for a hybrid cognitivist to go here (Tresan, 2006). Rather than relying on pragmatic notions about what ethical statements implicate (either conversationally or conventionally), they might argue that what makes a statement an *ethical* statement is that the speaker has a profile of desires, preferences, plans, etc. that is characteristic of people engaged in ethical discourse. More specifically, in order to count as participating in the practice of genuine ethical discourse, we might think someone must have whatever desire-like states are needed to explain the tight connection between ethical judgment and motivation. So, on this kind of view, it's not an implicature of a particular speech-act which ensures the presence of a desire-like state, rather this is part of what makes one's speech part of the language-game of ethics: one doesn't count as making an *ethical* statement unless one has the relevant desire-like state.

I've just put the point in terms of ethical *language*, but we can make the same point at the level of *thought*. That is, one might suggest that what makes a belief an *ethical* belief is that the believer has a profile of desires, preferences, plans, etc. that is characteristic of people engaged in ethical thought: more specifically, whatever desire-like states are needed to explain the tight connection between ethical judgment and motivation.

Like ecumenical expressivism, hybrid cognitivism also attempts to claim the best of both worlds. To assess them for yourself, you'll want to consider whether they integrate the desire-like element connected to ethical discourse in a plausible way. As naturalist views, these theories are also committed to making good on the challenge to explain which natural facts are the ethical facts. So, we'll still need to assess their ability to make ethical facts reduce to or otherwise fit with uncontroversially natural facts.

• ETHICAL FACTS—WHY DO THEY HAVE TO BE “OUT THERE”?

One might hold—as we've seen that error-theorists and fictionalists do—that representationalism is true but that no ethical facts objectively obtain, somehow “out there” in reality for us to discover. This seems to commit one to the radical view that atomic ethical beliefs and the statements that express them (such as your belief that murder is wrong or my statement that charity is good) are literally false. To avoid such radical commitments, many cognitivists are “success theorists,” in the sense that

they think at least some ethical facts obtain objectively, rendering some (possible atomic) ethical beliefs and statements true. As we've witnessed, however, this seems to commit realists to developing a metaphysical account of what objective ethical facts are like, and herein lay the challenges for metaethical nonnaturalism and non-naturalism that we discussed in previous chapters.

All of that might lead one into the expressivist's arms. But an alternative response to these challenges to representationalism is to suggest that we've got the wrong picture of what ethical facts would have to be like in order for our ethical claims to be true. By assuming they would have to be "objective" in the sense of antecedently there to be discovered by ethical inquiry, we occlude the possibility that ethical facts obtain, but are in some way significantly ontologically dependent in some way on our sentiments, reasoning, or points of view. On this kind of view, there are ethical facts but they aren't completely "out there" in the sense of characteristic of more robust forms of realism. There are several different ways to develop this line of thought, but here we'll focus on two core ideas: the idea that ethical facts are ontologically dependent on the hypothetical responses of some appropriately placed observer and the idea that ethical facts are "constructions" of human thought.

Response-dependence

Response-dependent views hold that an action's having an ethical property is ontologically dependent on how observers of some yet-to-be-specified kind under some yet-to-be-specified conditions would respond to the action.³ On some ways of developing that idea, it simply becomes the subjectivist form of the relativist view we considered in Chapter 5. You'll recall that the subjectivist claims that ethical facts are identical facts about the subjective values of different people. For example, the statement "It was wrong for Bush to start the war in Iraq" would be treated by the subjectivist as the expression of a belief about what follows from the speaker's own subjective ethical commitments or values.

Although views like these are sometimes considered antirealist, I suggested before that we might understand them as forms of naturalistic realism, albeit ones maintaining that at least some core ethical facts are not universal. As long as the ethical facts (construed as facts about the subjective values of different people) are in principle discoverable by empirical methods, we might maintain that they are as "out there" as any other empirically discoverable fact. At least they're as "objective" as facts about human psychology. For example, when Hume wrote, "[W]hen you pronounce any action or character to be vicious, you mean nothing, but that from the constitution of your nature you have a feeling or sentiment of blame from the contemplation of it" (2000, 469), it could mean that moral judgments are simply factual judgments about our own feelings.

However, that's probably not exactly Hume's fully considered view. And, in any case, there are related views that pursue more subtle strategies for fleshing out the idea that an action's having an ethical property is ontologically dependent on how observers of some yet-to-be-specified kind under some yet-to-be-specified conditions would respond to the action. These are more difficult to place within the realism/

antirealism dichotomy. They are also in a better position than subjectivism to respect many of our pretheoretic intuitions about ethics.

To see what kinds of view I have in mind, it can be helpful to make two cross-cutting distinctions regarding these views. First, metaethicists often distinguish between **sentimentalism** and **rationalism** as ways to develop versions of response-dependent views depending on the kinds of responses that are thought to be relevant to constituting ethical facts. Sentimentalists hold that it is the ideal observer's conative responses such as approval and disapproval that constitute morality; by contrast, rationalists hold that it is the ideal observer's beliefs (i.e. cognitive reactions) that something is good/bad that constitute morality. Second, metaethicists often distinguish between universalistic and relativistic versions of response-dependent views depending on whether one thinks that there is some one response that determines morality for everyone or the possibility of multiple incompatible responses determining morality for different groups of people.

If Hume wasn't a subjectivist, then it is likely that he accepted some sort of sentimentalist response-dependent view. Adam Smith also developed a view in this general direction. However, it is Firth (1952) who did the most to reintroduce response-dependent views into twentieth-century discussions of metaethics. He argued for a universalistic version of the view and at least suggests sentimentalism (though leaves open the precise psychological nature of the ethically relevant responses). His view was universalistic because he characterized an ideal observer whose dispositions to have an ethically significant reaction to something x were claimed to be determinative of whether x had the relevant ethical property. Firth argued that we could characterize the ideal observer by examining the abstract features of ethical decision making that we regard as rational to deploy. Doing this, he thought of the ideal observer as a kind of theoretical construct of what it would take to be the perfect ethical judge: someone who is omniscient with regard to the non-ethical facts, omnipercipient with regard to the types of things that one might experience, impartial concerning competing interests of any parties involved, dispassionate, consistent, but otherwise normal. Given this, then, a judgment such as "It was wrong for Bush to start the war in Iraq" would—on Firth's view—be true just in case Bush's starting the war would elicit negative ethical reaction from an omniscient, omnipercipient, impartial, dispassionate, consistent, but an otherwise normal judge.

This counts as sentimentalist insofar as we think of the ethical reaction as a sentimental and so "conative" response. For example, if we think of it as a negative emotion towards the object of ethical evaluation, then it's the ideal observer's disposition to have certain *sentiments* that ultimately grounds the wrongness of the action. On the other hand, one could use the same basic framework to develop a rationalist version of the response-dependent view by thinking of the relevant ethical reaction as a belief and so "cognitive" response to the object of ethical evaluation.

Another way to understand response-dependent views is by comparing ethical concepts to color concepts. It's not obvious that colors are response-dependent, but they're a pretty good candidate for something whose reality is in some sense in the eye of the (possible)

beholder. The rough idea is that the best handle we have on what it means to think of something as red, for example, is to think about what it would look like under ideal conditions for viewing something's color. It is relatively straightforward to characterize ideal conditions for seeing something's color: it has to be daylight; the observer cannot be wearing tinted glasses; drugs affecting color vision must be avoided, etc. Then, one might say that what it is for something to be red is just for it to be such that an ideal observer would think that it was red. Notice that this doesn't make something's color depend on the actual existence of an observer. Objects in a dark room where no one is observing would still count as red on this view. It's just that they would have to be such that *were* they observed by an ideal observer, that person would judge that they are red.

Metaethicists such as Johnston (1989), Lewis (1989), Smith (1994), and Prinz (2007) have sought to adapt this model to ethical values. I won't get into the (often complex) details of their views, except to say that the comparison can be used to develop all four possible combinations of sentimentalist/rationalist and universalistic/relativistic versions of the view. For example, Lewis develops a sentimentalist universalistic version of the view, while Smith develops a rationalist universalistic version of the view, and Prinz uses response-dependence to work out relativistic sentimentalism. Whatever the exact combination, the important point, for our present purposes, about the comparison to colors is that there seem to be facts about what colors things are, but these facts have seemed to many to be not as "out there" in the fabric of reality as other facts (such as facts about the chemical constitution of various substances). If that's right, and ethical facts are similarly response dependent, then we might have a view of ethical facts that treats them as perfectly real but not completely "out there" in the sense characteristically claimed by more robust forms of realism.

Key Point: Response-dependent views treat ethical facts as ontologically and/or conceptually dependent on the dispositions of some kind of observer to respond to things in certain ways. Because of this, ethical facts are less "out there" than facts ordinarily subject to empirical discovery.

It's worth noting in this context that one prominent way to develop the **divine command theory**, which we encountered briefly in the Introduction, is along the lines of a response-dependent view. The idea would be to appeal to *God* as the ideal agent, whose (perhaps merely hypothetical) responses to an action constitute its ethical rightness/wrongness.

Constructivism

A related but subtly different constellation of ideas proposes to treat ethical facts as "constructions" of practical reasoning rather than something obtaining independently that practical reasoning aims to discover. Working out this possibility is the heart of a contemporary view in metaethics known as **constructivism**.

Although the term comes from a view in the philosophy of mathematics (which construes mathematical truths as constructions of human thought rather than obtaining independently of our abilities to think abstractly), constructivists in metaethics are often inspired by the tradition of social-contract theory in political philosophy tracing through Hobbes, Rousseau, Kant, and Rawls. In the political context, the issue isn't ethical facts in general, but a species of ethical facts, such as facts about our rights.

One way to understand the basic idea is by thinking that facts about justice (e.g., what rights we have as members of a political community) are not something we could *discover* by some kind of empirical investigation, but rather something that is *constructed* out of the contours of a particular sort of practical challenge we face in living together. Rawls for example asked us to imagine an **original position** where people are designing the basic principles of society but behind a **veil of ignorance** about which particular people they will be in society they are legislating for. Participants in the original position are assumed to be applying various principles about how to choose principles to live by, and they are assumed to agree broadly on what sorts of things it takes to make a life go well (though they may have different conceptions of the good life). Rawls' thought then, is to construe facts about justice as having no independent status but rather as being constructions of this hypothetical choice situation: in sum, facts about justice (e.g., that free speech is a right) are constituted as what would be agreed to in the original position.

The key point for metaethics is the suggestion that the procedure for determining outcomes within a particular standpoint is fundamental in our understanding of what those facts are like. Accordingly, a constructivist about justice holds that there are facts about justice, but these facts aren't "objective" in the sense of standing free from the procedures of something like the original position that are used to determine them. Rather those facts are constituted by their emerging from certain procedures deployed from a particular standpoint (e.g., participants in the original position agreeing on what rights to confer to everyone).

As far as that goes, however, the constructivist position applies only to a species of ethical facts (facts about justice). However, a proponent of the view uses other apparently ethical concepts (principles about how to choose and agreement about what it takes for a life to go well) in their characterization of the procedure, emergence from which would constitute the relevant facts. As such, the constructivist position in political philosophy seems to just push the relevant metaethical questions back a stage: do claims about what choice principles participants of the original position use count as "representations" of some objective facts, do any such facts really obtain, and if so are they natural or nonnatural? How should we conceive of views about what it generally takes to make a life go well—are these cognitive representations of reality or noncognitive attitudes towards things or some kind of pretense? Because of this, constructivism about justice seems to be a complication we could add to any of our main metaethical views rather than a freestanding alternative to those views.

Hence, to have a constructivist view in *metaethics*, one needs to claim that *all* ethical facts are “constructions” rather than apt for discovery. However, this immediately raises a challenge. If we understand “constructions” as what emerges from some procedure, then constructivists face a dilemma (Hussain and Shah, 2006; Enoch, 2009). On the one hand, if the procedures are procedures we can characterize in completely naturalistic terms, then the view looks to be a fancy form of naturalistic realism rather than an alternative to it. On the other hand, if the procedures a constructivist appeals to are ones we must use irreducibly ethical (or at least normative) concepts to characterize, then the view looks to be a fancy form of nonnaturalistic realism.

QU3: Consider the view that something’s being valuable is constituted by its being such that an average person would value it at least a little bit. Why might one think that’s just a fancy form of naturalist realism?

In light of this challenge, recent metaethical constructivists such as Korsgaard (2003) and Street (2010) have tended to characterize their constructivism in terms of what follows from the “practical standpoint” rather than in terms of what would emerge from some hypothetical procedure. Their idea is to distinguish a disengaged point of view from which we might represent the value-free way things are in reality from an engaged point of view from which we take some things to be more and less valuable, thus generating reasons for us to act in various ways. This should remind you of the move expressivists make encouraging us to ask not about value (whose metaphysical status is controversial) but about valuing (which is conceived as a perfectly natural attitude humans and others might have towards something). However, unlike expressivists, constructivists then make claims about what the practical standpoint *as such* entails. The import of “as such” is to force us to think abstractly about practical reasoning in general rather than about one among several possible practical outlooks. The original position, as Rawls characterized it, imports substantive assumptions about what are better and worse ways to choose basic principles to live by, whereas a thoroughgoing form of constructivism would need to operate with a thinner or merely “formal” characterization of practical reasoning and the standpoint it comprises. In this way, constructivists hope to argue that one doesn’t count as taking some things to be more and less valuable unless one is committed to certain ethical facts.

Hence, according to metaethical constructivists, if there were no beings who could take some things to be valuable, then nothing would be valuable. For there to be reasons to act, there must be agents taking up the practical standpoint, trying to decide how to act. So, although constructivists conceive of ethical judgments as beliefs, and indeed beliefs which can be true because of the obtaining of the corresponding facts, these beliefs are not conceived as being about some piece of reality obtaining independently of the (at least possible) existence of agents taking up the practical standpoint. In this way, they’re importantly different from the way we standardly conceive of beliefs about the natural world.

Does that mean that ethical facts aren't *objective*? In a sense, yes. Constructivists hold that there are ethical facts but these are a construction of the practical standpoint rather than facts obtaining objectively in the sense of being "out there" independent of human modes of thought. However, in another sense, constructivism leaves the question about objectivity open. Korsgaard defends a "Kantian" version of constructivism, according to which certain *universal* ethical truths are entailed by the practical standpoint considered as such (or characterized merely formally). This means that there are some reasons every agent has, no matter what their particular desires or ends happen to be. If such universal norms of conduct are indeed entailed by the practical standpoint, considered as such, there would be another sense in which those ethical facts are objective, even though constructed. However, Street defends a "Humean" version of constructivism, according to which no substantive universal ethical truths are entailed by the practical standpoint considered as such. Instead, she thinks practical reasons emerge for an agent only once we add to the practical standpoint his or her particular and contingent cares and concerns. So, for her, there are no objective values, but only the values that follow from one's evaluative starting point when focussed through the practical standpoint.

Key Point: Metaethical constructivists hold that there are ethical facts but they are "constructed" rather than apt for discovery, in the sense that whatever reality they have depends on the standpoint of reasoning practically.

• PRAGMATISM

The main antirepresentationalist option among traditional metaethical theories is expressivism. Metaethical expressivists typically accept as a kind of default rule that declarative sentences are about the way reality is, and their distinctive claim is that ethical sentences are different: They are not best understood as representations of reality but rather expressions of something like emotion, preference, norm-acceptance, or plan. This is what makes expressivists antirepresentationalists *about ethical discourse*. As we have seen, this position promises advantages in metaphysics and the philosophy of mind, but it carries costs in epistemology and the philosophy of language.

Somewhat independently of metaethical debate, there is a tradition in the philosophy of language and mind that might be applied to ethical discourse and thought. And when it is, it would seem to carry some of the same advantages as expressivism, but it might avoid some of these costs. This is called **pragmatism**.

There are many different theses and theoretical persuasions going under the label "pragmatism" (which I won't attempt to survey here). The key claim that is relevant here is that there is a rich plurality of kinds of words and concepts, and that the best way to understand a particular word or the concept it expresses is not by asking what it stands for but by asking what it does for us in the various conceptually infused practices in which we humans engage. For example, consider the logical word 'not,' as in "Ian is *not*

at home.” In the pragmatist’s view, to understand the meaning of this word (and the concept it expresses) we should focus on what it does for us rather than on what it stands for. In this case, the beginning of a plausible account is that the word ‘not’ provides us a way to *reject* or *deny* something. We might end up saying that ‘not’ denotes *negation*. But according to the pragmatist this isn’t because there is some element of reality (not-ness?, negativity?) which a sentence (like the one about Ian) somehow represents, but rather because of the distinctive role this term has in the practice of rejecting and denying.

Here’s another example: consider the **epistemic modal** ‘might,’ as in “Ian *might* be at home.” Is there something this word refers to, such as the “might-ness” of Ian’s being at home that this sentence represents as part of reality, and whose nature we could investigate? The pragmatist thinks this is the wrong question to ask. Instead the pragmatist encourages us to ask about the function of the word ‘might’ in our practices. The beginning of a plausible account is that this word provides a means for qualifying an outright assertion relative to our evidence. For instance, rather than saying that Ian *is* at home, one says he *might* be at home when one cannot rule it out but also cannot assert it outright. By switching our focus from what terms refer to or what sentences represent to what function they play in our diverse practices, pragmatists hope to paint a more varied picture of language use (and conceptually infused thought).

This should sound familiar. When we discussed expressivism in Chapter 3, I said that expressivists typically encourage us to begin our metaethical enquiry by asking not about (i) the nature of some kind of supposedly real thing: ethical value, but about (ii) the nature of one of our practices: making ethical evaluations. Then, their answer to question (ii) typically claims some interesting disanalogy between ethical evaluations and representations of reality. We might now view this as an instance of the core pragmatist approach. But pragmatists typically go on to argue that the same approach should be applied outside of ethics—e.g., to logical terms such as ‘not,’ and to epistemic modals such as ‘might.’ This isn’t because statements containing these terms express desire-like attitudes rather than beliefs, but because their role in our practices is something other than representing pieces of reality (Chrisman, 2014). Indeed, pragmatists needn’t be committed to the characteristic expressivist answer to this question about ethical language. If there is a diverse plurality of kinds of words and concepts, each with different functions in our practices, then as long as we can find some function plausibly attributed to ethical words that isn’t one of representing ethical properties, and this function can be sustained without thinking of ethical words as also representational, we will have secured an antirepresentationalist account of ethical language. This means that pragmatists in metaethics gain whatever advantages are accorded to expressivism in virtue of their antirepresentationalism in the philosophy of language. Moreover, pragmatists have more flexibility to develop a nuanced account of the non-representational function of ethical thought (since expressing desire-like states doesn’t *have* to be part of the story as long as doing something other than representing reality is part of the story). This means that pragmatists in metaethics potentially improve on the advantages accorded to expressivism in virtue of its philosophy of mind.

What about the potential costs of expressivism in epistemology and the philosophy of language? Here, a lot is going to depend on the specific story about ethical discourse developed by pragmatists, but we can say something general. If ethical discourse isn't special in being nonrepresentational because there are other sorts of discourse that are nonrepresentational, then there cannot be a special problem about ethical knowledge and the semantics of ethical sentences stemming from the pragmatist claim that ethical discourse is not for representing reality. After all, something one might *know* is that Ian is not at home or that Ian might be at home. So, if these sentences aren't construed as representations of reality, we're going to need some more general pragmatist-friendly account of knowledge which is not of the way reality is.

Similarly, sentences containing 'might' and 'not' are clearly embeddable in semantically complex contexts such as in "if-then" conditionals. So if these sentences aren't construed as representations of reality, we're going to need some more general pragmatist-friendly account of the composition of semantically complex sentences containing these sentences as parts. (Notice that this is a kind of "partners-in-crime" response on the part of the metaethical pragmatist to the problems facing expressivism in epistemology and the philosophy of language.)

QU4: What might a metaethical pragmatist say to the objection that ethical sentences are clearly truth-apt and so must be seen as representations of reality?

Some philosophers have suggested that the pragmatist maneuver (of switching our focus from questions about the referents of words to their function in our diverse practices) will—insofar as it is successful—undermine the very idea of some bits of language representing pieces of reality. Indeed, some pragmatists have embraced this consequence, casting their view in the philosophy of language as a sort of **global expressivism**: where the expressivist thought only ethical language expresses rather than represents, the pragmatist says that all language expresses rather than represents (Price, 2011). One thing you'll want to consider as you evaluate metaethical pragmatism for yourself is whether this is indeed a consequence of the view, and, if so, whether it is a bad consequence.

• CONCLUSION

The main metaethical positions considered in the previous chapters broke into four categories based on three questions:

- 1 Do ethical facts obtain objectively? (Realism vs. Antirealism)
- 2 If so, do these facts reduce to or otherwise fit with the natural facts? (Naturalism vs. Nonnaturalism)
- 3 If not, do ethical statements/thoughts represent a way reality could be? (Error theory/Fictionalism vs. Expressivism)

In this chapter, however, we have seen how these categories can be challenged. In different ways, McDowellians, ecumenical expressivists, and hybrid cognitivists all argue that it's a false dichotomy to wonder whether ethical thoughts are representations of reality *or* motivational pressures on action, since they could possibly involve both. Response-dependent views and constructivist views hold that the question of whether ethical facts obtain objectively doesn't admit of a straightforward answer. Their view is that ethical facts are not "out there" waiting to be discovered, since they are ontologically dependent on the hypothetical responses of an ideal agent or obtain as "constructions" of the practical standpoint. Finally, pragmatists argue that there are other avenues for arguing that ethical statements/thoughts do not represent a way reality could be besides the expressivist claim that ethical statements are distinctive in expressing desire-like attitudes rather than beliefs.

In a much more tentative vein, we might try to capture the more complicated theoretical landscape with Figure 7.1.

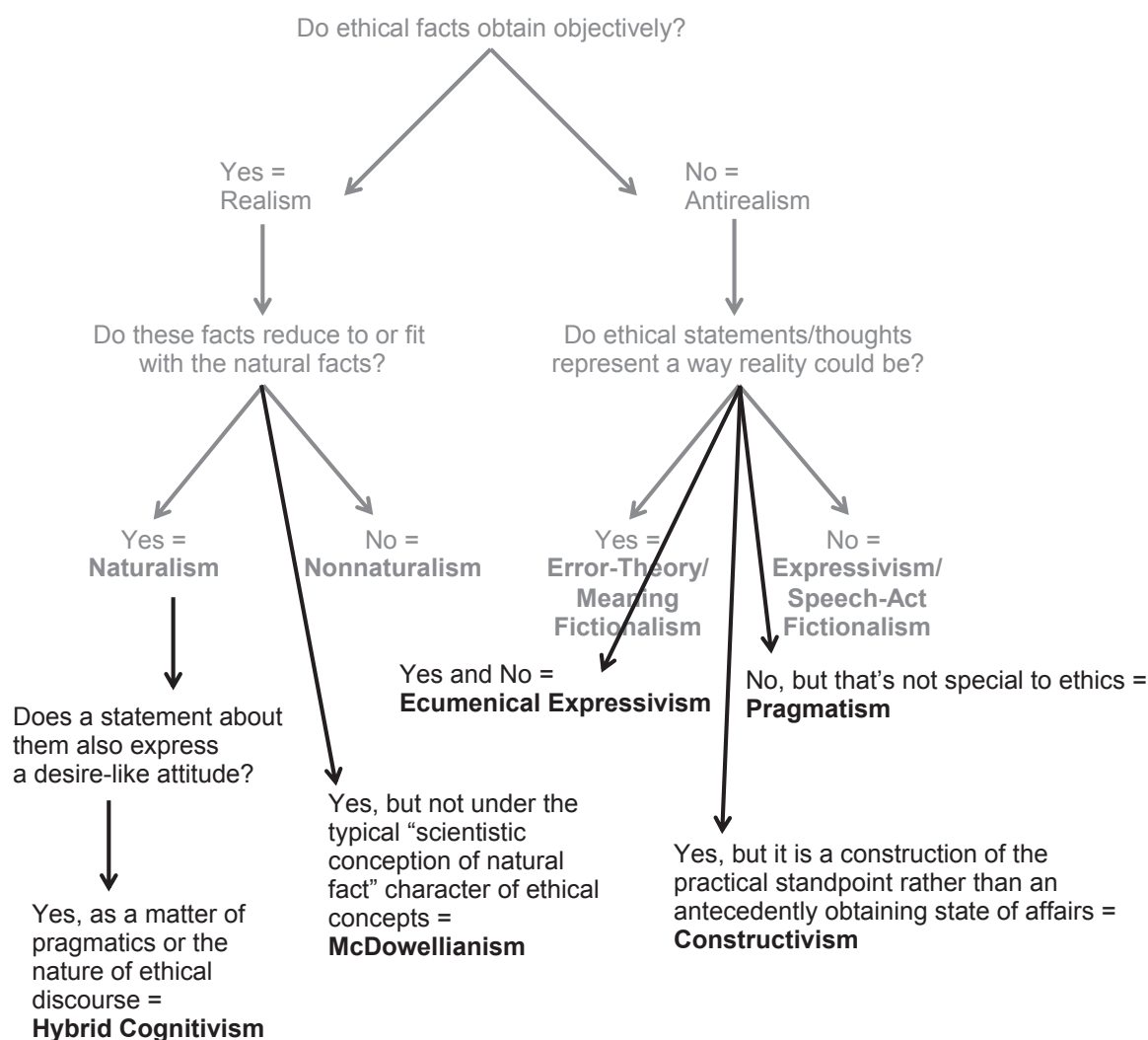


Figure 7.1 Some hard to classify metaethical theories

Metaethics is an exciting subdiscipline of philosophy in part because of the possibility of bringing to bear the methodology of theoretical cost–benefit analysis on these new positions in order to evaluate whether any of them are more attractive overall than the traditional positions. It is outside the scope of this book to explore these positions that break some of the traditional categories in any more detail. However, current debate in metaethics often addresses these (and some more) nuanced positions.

• CHAPTER SUMMARY

- McDowell argues that ethical judgments can both represent reality and motivate action because the conditions of possessing particular ethical concepts carry a requirement of having the practical wisdom to exercise these concepts correctly in action.
- Ecumenical expressivists argue that ethical statements express an amalgam state consisting of both a belief about reality and an interlocking desire-like pressure on action.
- Hybrid cognitivism is a form of metaethical naturalism that attempts to steal the motivation for expressivism by finding other ways to view ethical statements as expressing desire-like attitudes (in additions to beliefs about reality).
- Response-dependent views treat ethical facts as ontologically dependent on the hypothetical responses (either sentimental or rational) of idealized observers, and so in that sense not fully “out there” like other sorts of empirically discoverable facts.
- Constructivism in metaethics argues that ethical facts do not obtain objectively, in the sense of being “out there” to be discovered, but are rather constructions of the practical standpoint.
- Metaethical pragmatists argue that pragmatism as a general philosophy of language and mind provides different resources for an antirepresentationalist account of ethical language than traditional expressivism.

• STUDY QUESTIONS

- 1 How does McDowell’s Aristotle-inspired “naturalism” contrast with Hursthouse’s Aristotle-inspired “naturalism”?
- 2 Ecumenical expressivists are typically seen as antirealists drawing on the tradition of expressivism, whereas hybrid cognitivists are typically seen as realists drawing on the tradition of naturalism. What is the difference in their ontological commitments, and which side is better for this?
- 3 What’s the difference between constructivists in metaethics and quasi-realist expressivists?
- 4 What’s the difference between pragmatists in metaethics and quasi-realist expressivists?

• FURTHER RESOURCES

- Chrisman, Matthew. 2011. "Ethical Expressivism," in *The Continuum Companion to Ethics*. Continuum. [Covers ecumenical expressivism in more detail.]
- Chrisman, Matthew. 2014. "Attitudinal Expressivism and Logical Pragmatism," in Hubbs, G. and Lind, D. (eds.), *Pragmatism, Law, and Language*. Routledge: 117–35. [Introduces pragmatism in metaethics.]
- Finlay, Stephen. 2007. "Four Faces of Moral Realism," *Philosophy Compass* 2 (6): 820–49. [Discusses constructivism in more detail.]
- Fletcher, Guy and Ridge, Michael (eds.) 2014. *Having It Both Ways: Hybrid Theories and Modern Metaethics*. Oxford University Press. [A volume of collected essays on the "why not both" option.]
- Ridge, Michael. 2006. "Ecumenical Expressivism: Finessing Frege," *Ethics* 116 (2): 302–36. [Seminal essay introducing ecumenical expressivism.]
- Schroeder, Mark. 2009. "Hybrid Expressivism: Virtues and Vices," *Ethics* 119 (2): 257–309. [Influential essay comparing and contrasting various ways of working out the "why not both" option.]
- Street, Sharon. 2010. "What is Constructivism in Ethics and Metaethics?" *Philosophy Compass* 5: 363–84. [Introductory essay on constructivism.]

• ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS OF UNDERSTANDING

- QU1: The Humean will insist that we can separate belief in a particular fact from desire-setting goals that move us in light of our beliefs. So even if people happen to be motivated not to do things they think are nasty, this will be because (a) they also have a desire to avoid doing nasty things, or (b) the thought that something is nasty is more like a preference not to do it rather than a representation of it as having a particular property. If this is right, for whatever interlocking pairs of cognitive representations of reality and goal-setting motivational state one has, we could always imagine some possible person having one of them but not the other. McDowell argues in contrast that some cognitive representations necessarily also carry goal-setting motivations.
- QU2: This statement implicates that Joe was one of the least likely to pass the test, and so the test was probably very easy. This is a *conventional* implicature because it is part of the conventionalized linguistic role of 'even' in this sentence. (Notice how we don't require any particular set up of the conversational context to tell what implicature this statement carries.)
- QU3: It's plausible that valuing something is a completely natural attitude (something like the attitude of preferring or taking pleasure in). And if that's right, then, according to the view sketched above, something's being valuable would in the end be a matter of whether the average person prefers it or takes pleasure in it. Since this is a natural fact, facts about what's valuable are natural facts.

QU4: Pragmatists will deny that truth is in general a matter of correct representation of reality. Indeed the minimalist theory of truth we encountered in Chapter 3 can be viewed as another instance of the general pragmatist approach: ask not about what ‘true’ refers to but rather about what this word does for us in our diverse practices.

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• NOTES

- 1 Some of McDowell's critics use the term **besire** (as an amalgamation of 'belief' and 'desire') to refer to McDowell's proposal that ethical beliefs necessarily carry motivational effect. This is not McDowell's term, and it is not clear that McDowell thinks every application of an ethical concept in a belief requires the attendant desire. But it's worth knowing the term as it is sometimes used in metaethical discussions as a term of mild derision for views that propose to expand our standard stock of psychological concepts, which includes beliefs and desires, to include one more which is the supposedly unseparable amalgam of both of the other two.
- 2 The term "ecumenical expressivism" is due to Ridge (2006). For similar views, see Schroeder (2009), Toppinen (2013), and Ridge (2014).
- 3 Some (e.g. McDowell, 1985, Wiggins, 1987, and McNaughton, 1988) argue that it's not how some agent *would* respond that constitutes the ethical properties of an action, but how they *should* respond. More specifically, they speak of an action's "meriting" or "warranting" various responses. While these are important and interesting views that can be difficult to place within the standard map of metaethical theories, I wouldn't classify these as response-dependent views in the sense relevant here unless they are explaining the notion of meriting or warranting a response that requires ineliminable reference to an observer. Otherwise, ethical properties are not ontologically dependent on the observer's responses; rather the correctness of the observer's responses is determined by independently obtaining ethical facts.